Canadian Housing Market Analysis

Top 45 Cities Across Canada

ALY 6000 | Project 4C | Independent Data Analysis

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35,768 Listings | 45 Cities | 9 Provinces

Data as of October 29, 2023 | Source: Kaggle

1. Introduction

Canada's housing market is one of the most discussed economic issues in the country today. For millions of Canadians — especially younger families and first-time buyers — the question of whether they can afford to own a home is deeply personal. For banks and financial institutions, it is also a risk management question: when home prices far exceed what local families actually earn, the risk of mortgage default rises significantly.

This report analyses 35,768 residential property listings across Canada's 45 most populous cities, collected on October 29, 2023. After cleaning and removing data entry errors, 34,381 listings remained for analysis. The dataset covers 9 provinces and includes listing price, number of bedrooms, number of bathrooms, city population, and median family income per city.

Research Questions

Q1. How do listing prices vary across Canadian provinces?

Q2. Which cities have the highest and lowest median listing prices?

Q3. Do cities with higher family incomes have proportionally higher home prices?

Q4. Which cities are the least — and most — affordable relative to family income?

Dataset at a Glance

Metric	Value
Total Raw Listings	35,768
Listings After Cleaning	34,381 (1,387 outliers removed)
Cities Covered	45 cities
Provinces Covered	9 provinces
National Median Price	$699,000 CAD
National Mean Price	$879,832 CAD
Listings Under $500K	29.3%
Listings Over $1 Million	26.3%
Data Collection Date	October 29, 2023

How the Data Was Cleaned

Before any analysis, the raw data was inspected for errors and outliers. The following records were removed because they are not representative of standard residential listings:

2. Provincial Price Disparities

The first and most striking finding in this analysis is how dramatically home prices differ depending on which province you live in. Canada is not one housing market — it is nine very different ones.

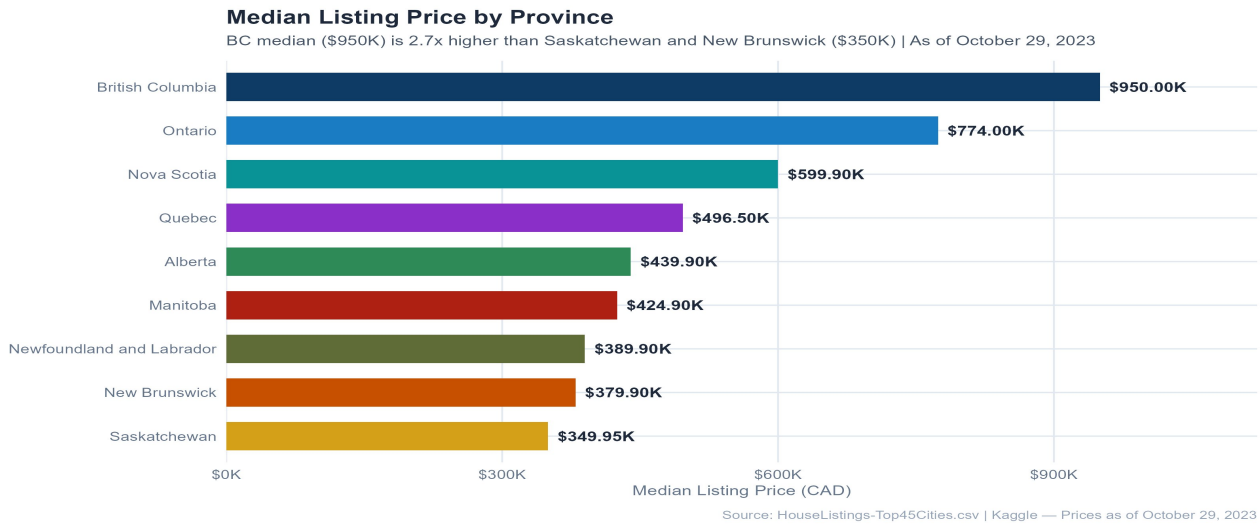

Figure 1. Median listing price by province, sorted from highest to lowest. Data as of October 29, 2023. Source: HouseListings-Top45Cities.csv | Kaggle.

What This Chart Shows

Each bar represents the median listing price for all residential homes in that province. The median is the middle value — half of listings are above it, half are below. It is a better measure than the average because it is not distorted by a small number of extremely expensive or cheap properties.

Key Findings

British Columbia — $950,000

BC has the highest median home price in Canada by a wide margin. A typical home in BC costs nearly one million dollars. This is driven primarily by Vancouver, White Rock, and other Lower Mainland cities where demand is extremely high.

Ontario — $774,000

Ontario ranks second, pulled upward by the Greater Toronto Area, Caledon, and Guelph. At $774K, the median Ontario home is still significantly more expensive than most other provinces.

Saskatchewan and New Brunswick — ~$350,000

These two provinces sit at the bottom of the ranking with a median of roughly $350,000. That is more than 2.7 times cheaper than British Columbia — for a home in the same country, under the same federal mortgage rules.

The National Gap

The gap between the most expensive province (BC at $950K) and the least expensive (Saskatchewan at $350K) is $600,000. This means where you choose to live in Canada has a larger impact on your housing costs than almost any other financial decision you make.

3. City-Level Price Rankings

Zooming in from provinces to individual cities reveals an even sharper picture. Not all cities within a province behave the same way — and the gap between the most expensive and least expensive cities is enormous.

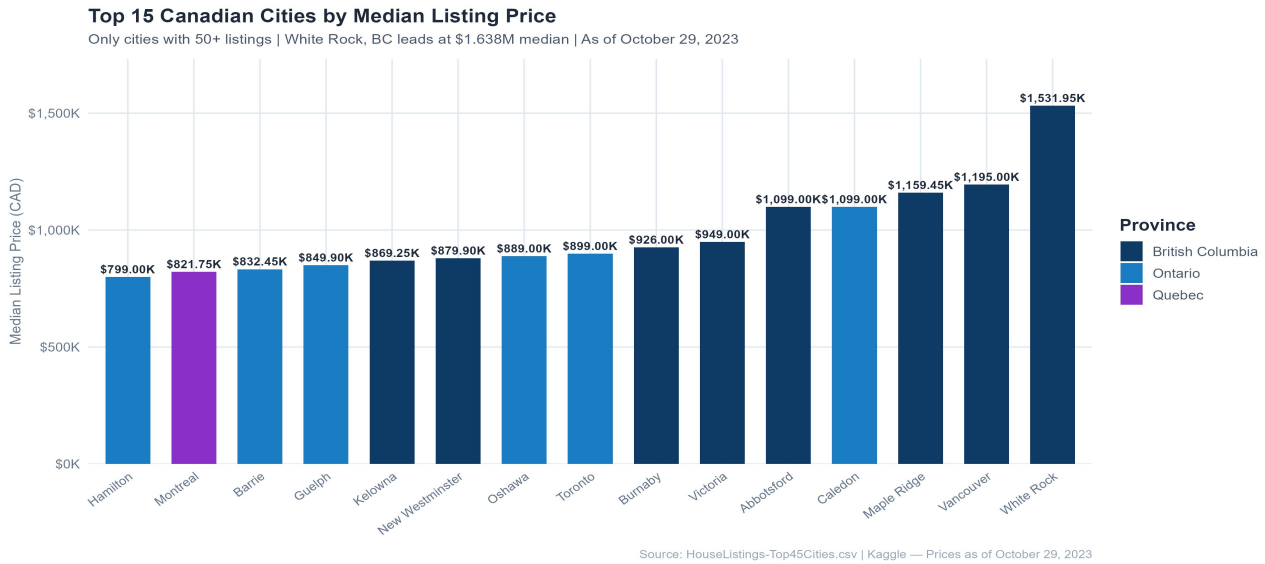

Figure 2. Top 15 Canadian cities by median listing price. Only cities with 50 or more listings are included to ensure statistical reliability. Data as of October 29, 2023. Source: HouseListings-Top45Cities.csv | Kaggle.

What This Chart Shows

Each bar represents one city, ranked from least to most expensive (left to right). The color of the bar tells you which province that city is in — dark navy for British Columbia, medium blue for Ontario, and purple for Quebec. Only cities with 50 or more listings are included because a city with only 3 or 4 listings would give a misleading median.

Key Findings

White Rock, BC — $1,531,950

White Rock is Canada's most expensive city in this dataset with a median price of $1.53 million. It is a small coastal city in Metro Vancouver, and its prices reflect extreme demand combined with very limited land supply.

BC Dominates the Top Tier

The top 6 most expensive cities — White Rock, Vancouver, Maple Ridge, Abbotsford, Victoria, and Burnaby — are all in British Columbia. This reinforces that BC is in a housing category of its own compared to the rest of Canada.

Toronto — $899,000

Toronto is the most expensive Ontario city and ranks 8th nationally at $899,000. Despite being Canada's largest city, it is actually less expensive than several BC cities.

Caledon, Ontario — $1,099,000

Caledon is a suburban municipality north of Toronto. Its median price of $1.1M shows how the affordability crisis has spread far beyond Toronto's city limits into surrounding communities.

4. Income vs. Price — The Mortgage Risk Map

One of the most important questions for banks and mortgage lenders is not just how expensive homes are — but whether the people living in those cities can actually afford them. This chart answers that question directly.

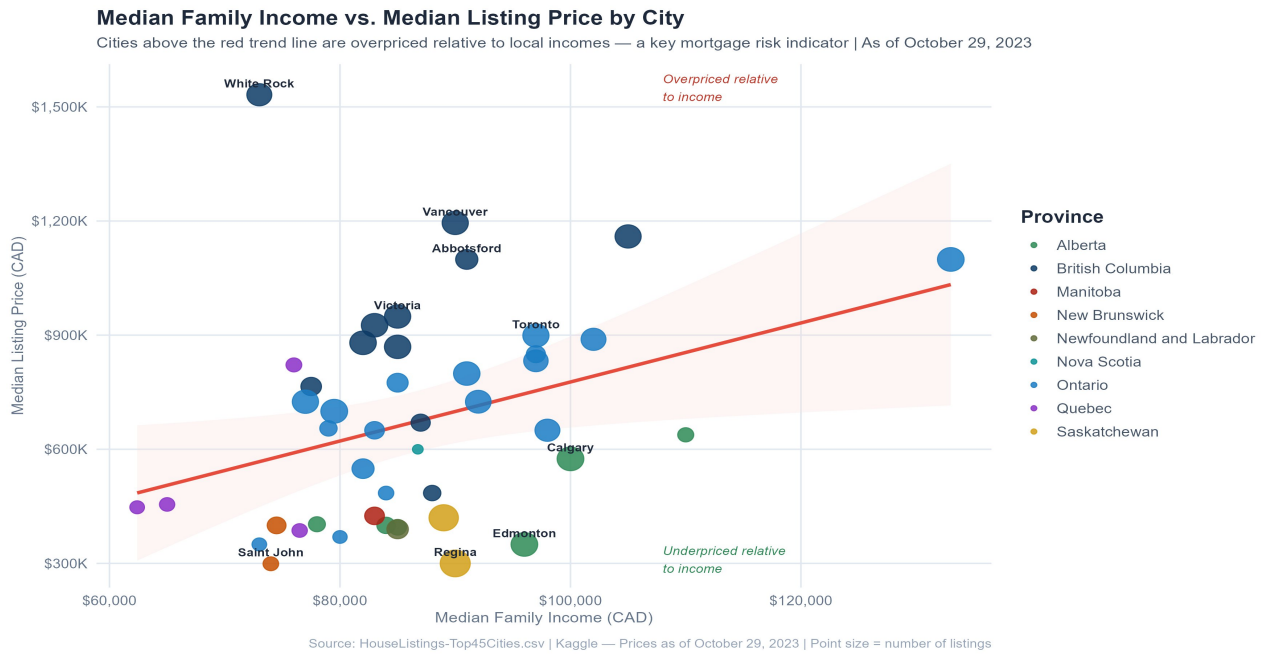

Figure 3. Scatter plot of median family income (horizontal axis) vs. median listing price (vertical axis) for each city. Point size represents the number of listings in that city. Data as of October 29, 2023. Source: HouseListings-Top45Cities.csv | Kaggle.

How to Read This Chart

This chart plots every city as a dot. The position of each dot tells you two things:

Horizontal position (left to right): How much families in that city typically earn. Cities on the left have lower incomes; cities on the right have higher incomes.

Vertical position (up or down): How expensive homes in that city are. Cities higher up have more expensive homes.

What Is the Red Line?

The red diagonal line is called a regression line (also known as a trend line or line of best fit). In plain English, it answers this question: if home prices were perfectly proportional to local incomes, where would each city's dot fall? The red line shows that expected relationship.

The pink shaded band around the red line is called a confidence interval. It shows the range of uncertainty around the trend — think of it as the line's 'margin of error'. Cities whose dots fall inside the band are behaving roughly as expected. Cities far outside the band are outliers that need attention.

Above the Line = Overpriced. Below the Line = Underpriced.

Cities whose dots sit above the red line have home prices that are higher than you would predict based on local incomes alone. This means residents are stretching further financially to afford housing — which increases the risk of mortgage default for lenders.

Cities below the red line have home prices that are lower than expected given local incomes. Residents in these cities have more financial breathing room — which represents lower mortgage risk.

Key Findings

White Rock, Vancouver, Abbotsford — Severely Overpriced

These three BC cities sit dramatically above the red line. White Rock is the most extreme outlier in the entire dataset — its home prices are far higher than what local family incomes would predict. This signals a very high concentration of mortgage risk in these markets.

Regina and Edmonton — Underpriced Relative to Income

Both cities sit below the red line, meaning their home prices are lower than what you would expect given local incomes. Residents have better financial capacity to service a mortgage — making these lower-risk markets for lenders.

The Income-Price Correlation Is Moderate, Not Strong

If income perfectly predicted price, all dots would sit exactly on the red line. The fact that they are scattered widely tells us that income alone does not drive Canadian home prices — other factors like land supply, foreign investment, and speculation play a significant role, particularly in BC.

5. Housing Affordability Ratio

The affordability ratio is a single number that captures how difficult it is to buy a home in a given city relative to what people there actually earn. It is calculated by dividing the median listing price by the median family income.

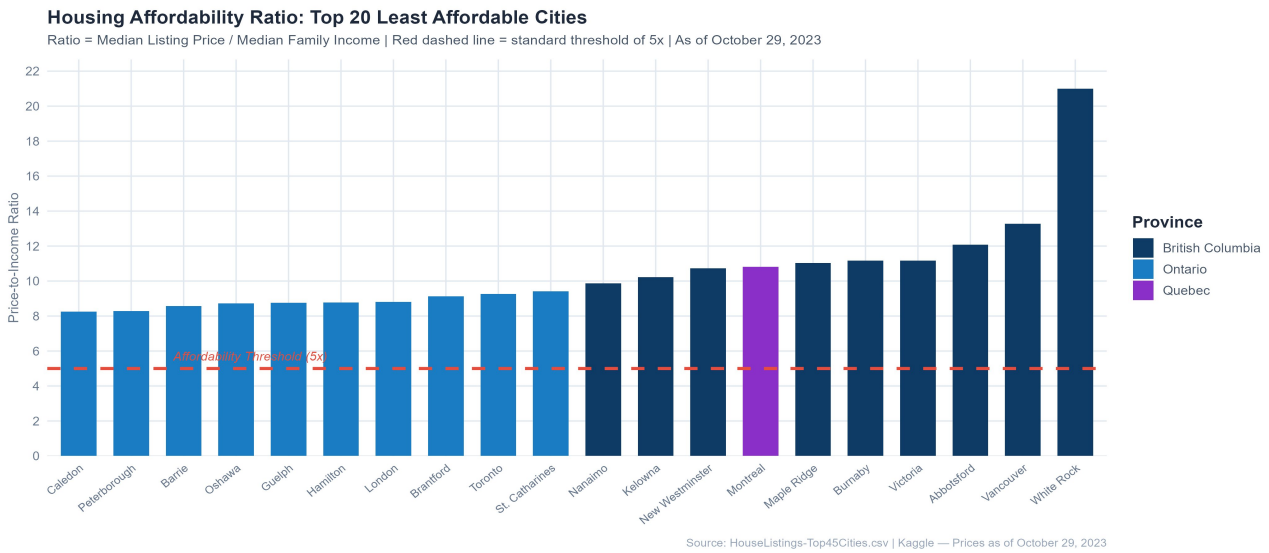

Figure 4. Housing affordability ratio for the 20 least affordable cities in Canada. The red dashed line marks the internationally recognised affordability threshold of 5x. Data as of October 29, 2023. Source: HouseListings-Top45Cities.csv | Kaggle.

What Is the Affordability Ratio?

Think of it as the answer to this question: how many years of a family's entire gross income would it take to buy the median home in that city — if they spent every dollar they earned and saved nothing else?

> Example: White Rock ratio = 21x means a family earning the local median income would need 21 FULL YEARS of income to afford the median home.

What Is the Red Dashed Line?

The red dashed line sits at a ratio of 5x. This is the internationally recognised threshold used by housing economists and policymakers around the world. A ratio below 5x means housing is considered affordable — families can reasonably manage a mortgage on their income. A ratio above 5x means housing is officially unaffordable by global standards.

Key Findings

White Rock — 21x (Critically Unaffordable)

At 21 times the median family income, White Rock is by far the least affordable city in Canada. With a median listing price of $1,532,000 and a median family income of only $73,000, the gap between earnings and home prices is extreme. This level of unaffordability poses serious financial risk for both buyers and lenders.

Every BC City Exceeds the 5x Threshold

Vancouver (13.3x), Abbotsford (12.1x), Burnaby and Victoria (both 11.2x), and Maple Ridge (11x) all far exceed the 5x threshold. Not a single city in British Columbia falls within an affordable range by global standards.

Montreal — 10.8x (Surprisingly Unaffordable)

Montreal is the only Quebec city in the top 20 least affordable list. Despite being generally seen as more affordable than Toronto or Vancouver, its ratio of 10.8x shows that even Montreal has a serious affordability problem relative to local incomes.

Toronto — 9.3x

Toronto's ratio of 9.3x places it firmly in the unaffordable range. With a median listing of $899,000 against a median family income of $97,000, Toronto families face significant financial pressure when purchasing a home.

6. Provincial Market Composition by Price Tier

Knowing the median price of a province is useful — but it only tells you the middle. This chart goes further by showing the full structure of each provincial market: what percentage of listings fall into each price tier.

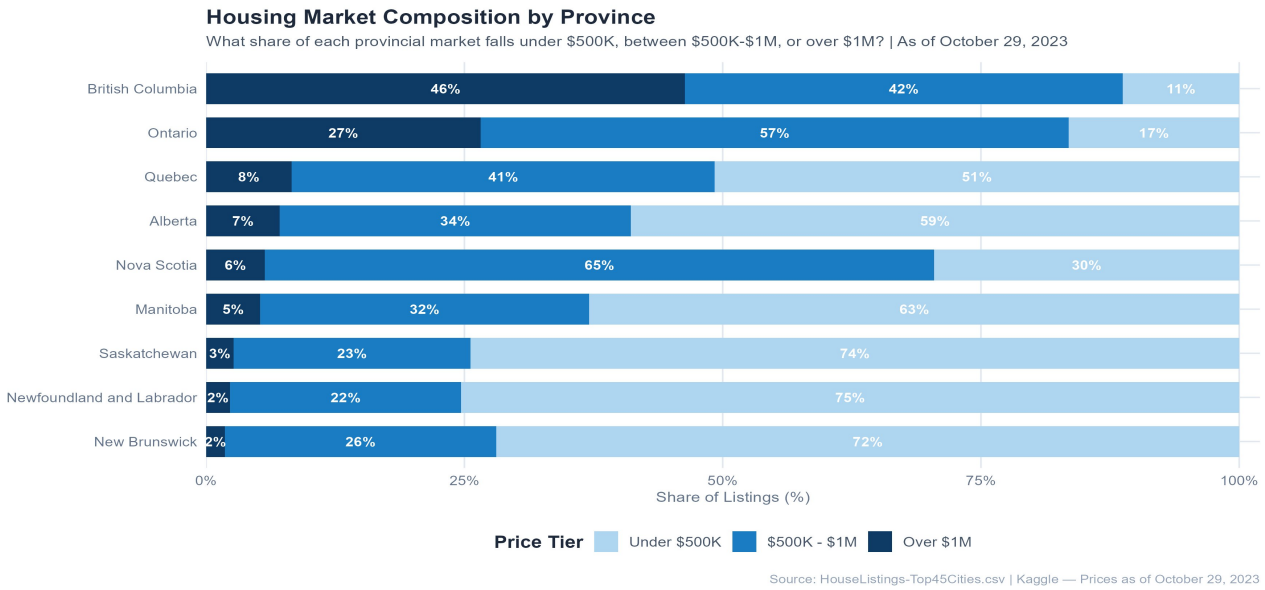

Figure 5. 100% stacked bar chart showing the share of listings in each price tier (Under $500K, $500K–$1M, Over $1M) by province, ordered from most luxury-heavy (top) to most affordable (bottom). Data as of October 29, 2023. Source: HouseListings-Top45Cities.csv | Kaggle.

How to Read This Chart

Each bar represents one province and is always 100% wide — the full bar equals all listings in that province. The bar is then divided into three colour segments:

Dark navy (left segment): Share of listings priced over $1 million.

Medium blue (middle segment): Share of listings priced between $500K and $1 million.

Light blue (right segment): Share of listings priced under $500K.

Key Findings

British Columbia — 46% of listings over $1 Million

Nearly half of all residential listings in BC are priced above $1 million. Only 11% of BC listings fall below $500K. This makes BC the most luxury-concentrated housing market in Canada — and the one with the least affordable stock.

Ontario — Evenly Split Across Tiers

Ontario is the most balanced market: 27% over $1M, 57% between $500K–$1M, and 17% under $500K. The $500K–$1M tier dominates, reflecting the broad mid-range market driven by smaller Ontario cities beyond Toronto.

Saskatchewan, Newfoundland, New Brunswick — Majority Under $500K

In Saskatchewan, 74% of listings are priced under $500K. In Newfoundland and Labrador, that figure is 75%, and in New Brunswick, 72%. These markets represent genuinely accessible housing for average Canadian families.

Alberta — Mostly Affordable Despite Oil Wealth

Despite Alberta's reputation for high incomes due to the oil industry, 59% of listings are under $500K. This is partly because Alberta cities like Calgary and Edmonton have more developable land, which keeps supply higher and prices lower.

7. Most vs. Least Affordable Cities

The final visualisation brings the affordability story to its sharpest possible focus — a direct side-by-side comparison of the 5 cities where housing is most accessible and the 5 cities where it is most out of reach.

Figure 6. Side-by-side comparison of Canada's 5 most affordable (green) and 5 least affordable (navy) cities by price-to-income ratio. Each bar is labelled with the ratio and the median listing price. The red dashed line marks the 5x threshold. Data as of October 29, 2023. Source: HouseListings-Top45Cities.csv | Kaggle.

How to Read This Chart

The chart is split into two panels. The left panel (green bars) shows the 5 most affordable cities — where bars are short and sit close to or below the red dashed line. The right panel (navy bars) shows the 5 least affordable cities — where bars are very long and far to the right of the red line. Each bar is labelled with two numbers: the ratio (e.g. '3.33x') and the median listing price (e.g. '$300K').

What Is the Red Dashed Line Here?

The red dashed line again marks the 5x affordability threshold. In the left panel (most affordable cities), notice how the green bars land just around or slightly below the red line — these cities are right at the edge of affordability. In the right panel (least affordable cities), the bars don't even come close to the line — they start past it and extend far beyond. That visual gap is the Canadian housing crisis in one image.

Key Findings

Most Affordable: Regina (3.33x), Edmonton (3.64x), Saint John (4.04x)

Regina, Saskatchewan has a median home price of $300,000 against a median family income of $90,000 — a ratio of 3.33x, the most affordable city in the analysis. Edmonton and Saint John are similarly accessible. These Prairie and Atlantic cities represent the last genuinely affordable large urban markets in Canada.

Least Affordable: White Rock (21x), Vancouver (13.3x), Abbotsford (12.1x)

The contrast could not be more dramatic. White Rock's ratio of 21x means a family would need 21 years of their entire income to afford the median home. Vancouver's ratio is 13.3x and Abbotsford's is 12.1x. All five least affordable cities are in British Columbia.

The Gap Between Best and Worst Is 6x

The difference between the most affordable city (Regina at 3.33x) and the least affordable (White Rock at 21x) is a factor of more than 6. This extraordinary gap within a single country highlights why the national housing debate often feels different depending on where in Canada you live.

8. Summary of Key Findings

#	Finding	Implication
1	BC median ($950K) is 2.7x higher than Saskatchewan ($350K)	Canada has no single housing market — location determines affordability more than any other factor
2	All 5 most expensive cities are in British Columbia	BC faces a structural supply crisis that individual buyers cannot solve on their own

3	BC cities sit far above the income-price regression line	BC prices are decoupled from local earnings — signalling elevated mortgage default risk
4	46% of BC listings are priced over $1 million	The majority of BC's housing stock is out of reach for families on average incomes
5	White Rock affordability ratio: 21x | Regina: 3.33x	The gap between Canada's least and most affordable markets is larger than in almost any other developed country

Future Research Questions

1. How have listing prices trended year-over-year in each province? A time-series analysis would reveal whether the gap between BC and other provinces is widening or narrowing.

2. What is the impact of proximity to major employment hubs on listing price? Adding commute distance data could explain why cities like Caledon and Maple Ridge are so expensive despite being far from downtown cores.

3. Can the income-to-price deviation predict mortgage default rates? Connecting this dataset to CMHC mortgage arrears data would allow banks to quantify the risk premium for lending in overpriced markets.

4. Are there seasonal patterns in listing volume and price by city? Monthly data would reveal whether prices peak in spring (typical in Canadian real estate) and whether this varies by province.

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